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MTEC 4502 - Career and Portfolio Seminar
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Assignment 1a: Speculation & Self-Assessment

1. Introduction to Career Aspirations

I got into technology when I was a kid, and gaming was the biggest reason. At first, I mostly played games. Then I started downloading mods, changing things, trying editing tools, and teaching myself through YouTube. That led me into design and website building, and eventually into experimenting with home-network security and firewalls. I kept finding something new to try. I originally wanted to become a game developer, but my interests have grown beyond that since then.

I study Emerging Media at City Tech, and I still don't have one fixed career plan. I want to design, code, and build things with AI. Game design still interests me, and so does cybersecurity. Sometimes I feel like I might become a jack of all trades. I enjoy exploring different things, but I am still trying to figure out where I fit and which interests I want to take further.

My current hands-on project is Donna, my personal AI assistant. My vision is similar to Jarvis: something that can talk to me, react to me, and work with the technology I give it access to. Eventually, I want it to help manage my phone, emails, home, and other digital systems. I also want to explore whether it could help me set up and run an online business. My goal would be for it to cover its own costs and eventually make a profit, but I don't know what that business would be yet. What keeps me interested is seeing an idea become something I can actually use.

2. Tools, Skills, and Knowledge for Success

Right now, I work with OpenAI models and use n8n for automation. I have experimented with tools such as OpenClaw and Hermes, and I keep looking for things on GitHub that I can connect to my system. Donna helps me build portfolio websites, troubleshoot desktop issues, and work through coding problems. I also use it for research and to help me understand things I am learning. It already does useful work, but it is still far from the dependable assistant I imagine. I keep experimenting with its configuration and trying to understand its limitations.

One working example is my email workflow. I can tell Donna to write and send an email on my behalf. It acts as my secretary rather than pretending to be me. That distinction matters to me. If I give a system access to something personal, I want to understand what it is doing and how it represents me.

For the kind of work I am interested in, I believe I need a stronger understanding of programming, automation workflows, and how different tools communicate. I also think design matters because something can work technically and still be awkward to use. Security matters too, especially when a system has access to emails, calendars, or devices. I need to understand how to test these systems and recognize when something is unreliable. Connecting tools is one part of the work; keeping them working is another.

3. Self-Assessment (Strengths & Growth Areas)

My biggest strength is that I keep experimenting. I have made different projects on GitHub, although I deleted most of them. Trying different tools has taught me what to avoid. When Donna makes a mistake, I ask questions and investigate instead of assuming it is correct.

My coding knowledge is still limited. I can follow the basic structure of a codebase, but I can't build or fix everything myself. Often, I can recognize where something is going wrong and use AI to help fix it. I need to understand the code better so I can judge those changes more confidently.

I recently helped start the Intelligence Society and became its treasurer. In practice, I contribute more as a technical person. The president has the stronger engineering background, and I support him with what I have learned from testing different tools and systems. I have finally found friends who share my interests and whose values and ethics line up with mine. As an international student, I had felt like a loner. Sometimes I feel like the least experienced person in the room, but I am glad to be in that room. I can contribute what I know and learn from them.

My main constraints are limited time and money, gaps in my coding knowledge, and difficulty choosing a direction. Being an international student adds restrictions and other things to manage. I have a lot of ideas, but I haven't focused on one specific path.

4. Initial Strategic Thoughts

Over the next one to three years, I think my first step is to use Donna as a project I can keep learning through. Instead of constantly adding another tool, I could spend more time understanding the systems I already have: how the email workflow runs, why something fails, and what makes a fix dependable. Learning programming through problems I actually encounter feels like a practical place to start.

The club gives me people to learn from and a place to contribute my experience. Finishing smaller projects and documenting my contribution would give me clearer work to show than a list of experiments.

I am still interested in an online business, but I haven't identified what I would offer or why someone would pay for it. That needs more thought before I can call it a plan. For now, meaningful progress would be stronger technical knowledge, more reliable projects, and a better understanding of which work I enjoy enough to keep doing. I don't know my final job title yet, but I have a project to keep working on and people I can learn with. For me, that is a clearer starting point than I had before.